

STATEMENT OF TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

Katie Apker

PhD Candidate - Cornell University

Organizational Behavior - ILR School

My goal in the classroom is to create an environment where students feel energized, safe to not know everything upfront, and pushed to interrogate their priors.

Bring the energy. If a classroom feels like drudgery, even excellent material can fail to connect. In my time instructing various classes, I have tried to bring enthusiasm and humor to the room. I have found that bringing good energy can be a fantastic ingredient for effective learning. This does not mean overly simplifying difficult ideas or being informal for its own sake. For me it means signaling personal approachability, while still preparing deeply enough that I can explain complicated material naturally, respond thoughtfully to students' contributions, and adapt the discussion dynamically without relying on an overly scripted or strict lecture.

Make learning approachable. Making the hidden rules and social mores of intellectual discussions explicit and plain has also been a habit I have tried to develop in the classroom. When introducing niche jargon or terminology, I try to define it clearly and acknowledge when a term may be new or unfamiliar to a student. For example, when teaching Weber and Foucault, I make sure students know how those tricky names are pronounced for those who may not have yet encountered them, and openly note that I did not always know either. To me, small moments like this communicate an important principle: there is no shame in not initially knowing and we are learning together. I ask many questions myself, try to acknowledge the limits of my expertise where appropriate, and want students to see questions as evidence of engagement, curiosity, and growth, rather than inadequacy. Students will likely not take intellectual risks if they are preoccupied with appearing perfectly informed before learning has even begun (a behavior I have observed all too often in the classroom).

Demand the students rethink. I would also argue that a classroom can be approachable but still demanding. I want students to leave with more than a set of concepts they need to memorize for an exam. Instead, I hope that their time in my class might also help them become more thoughtful about the assumptions they bring - willing to revise their views when the evidence is incomplete or contested - equipping them to make nuanced decisions throughout their careers and lives. That kind of learning happens when students feel they fully belong in the classroom, while also knowing that I will challenge them to defend their reasoning and reconsider it when necessary.

To cultivate this kind of environment, I often respond to a student's (perhaps overly) confident argument with, "I don't know. . ." followed by questions about the evidence that might complicate their assertions. My purpose is not to catch students making mistakes or prove that I know more. Instead, I want them to practice reasoning through counterarguments and deciding what they would do to grapple with new information, while still feeling acknowledged and valued. Case discussions

are especially useful for developing this kind of disciplined openness. The cases reliably divide classes, giving students the opportunity to articulate their initial judgments and confront evidence that complicates them. Rather than steering everyone toward an immediate consensus, I try to press each side to examine what its position assumes, what information it privileges, and what risks or different information it overlooks. The goal is not necessarily agreement in the end, but to learn to revise a judgment without treating revision as defeat or a signal that they are inadequate themselves.

Teaching Experience. My teaching has spanned undergraduate, MBA, and Executive MBA classrooms. At Cornell's ILR School, I have served as a teaching assistant for "Sociology of Work," a macro organizational behavior course, and "Psychology of Work," a micro organizational behavior course, leading two weekly discussion sections of roughly 25 students and designing, adapting, and supplementing my own lesson plans, slides, and learning activities. Students rated my overall teaching 4.71 out of 5 across these courses. I have also assisted with "Managing and Leading in Organizations" and "Strategic Management of Technology and Innovation" at Cornell's Johnson School of Business, as well as "Creative Strategic Thinking" and "Corporate Finance" at BYU Marriott School of Business. These experiences, together with my MBA and my real-world experience building and exiting a digital content business, help me connect organizational theory to the decisions real managers and entrepreneurs face.

Future Teaching. In the future, I am particularly excited to teach courses related to entrepreneurship, organizational behavior (macro or micro), and content at the intersection of organizations and emerging technology. My coursework in organizational behavior and organization theory, as well as my research on digital entrepreneurship, the social dynamics of work, and the role of evolving technology in shaping work inform how I approach teaching. I am also eager to develop a macro organizational behavior course that takes agentic AI seriously as an organizational issue. Managing AI is not simply a matter of technical training. It raises fundamental questions about divisions of labor, organizational structure, expertise, and authority. The same holds inside the classroom: I value both analogue teaching tactics and the integration of AI tools where they genuinely deepen learning, given the quickly evolving landscape of AI and LLM tools at our disposal. I am not one to try to forbid and authoritatively enforce - I have found that it is more effective and pragmatic to teach the spirit and intuition of when and how to use these tools, so that students maximize their learning and remain competitive in a landscape that will keep evolving. Across these topics, my aim remains consistent: to create a high-energy classroom where students can ask questions without embarrassment, engage seriously with difficult ideas, and leave with food for thought that they can carry with them.